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The Securitization Equilibrium: A NERAI Probability Forecast for Russian Regime Stability and Coup Risk Through May 2027

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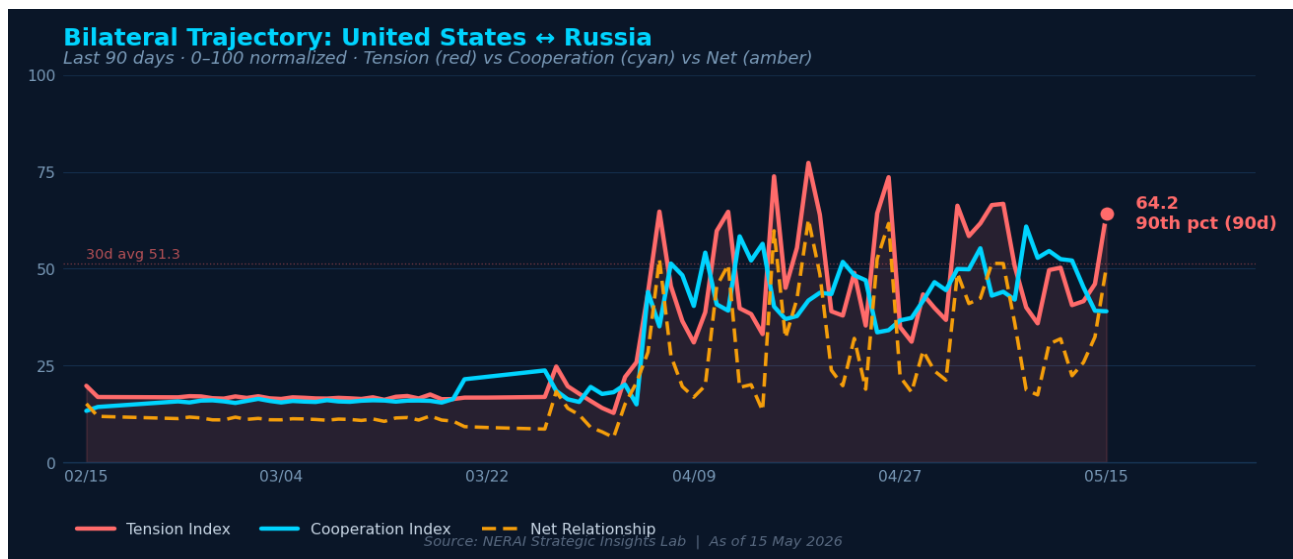
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EXECUTIVE SUMMARY



The May 4, 2026 IStories disclosure of an EU intelligence assessment concerning Putin's heightened fear of assassination and coup has triggered a measurable upward shift in NERAI's Russia coup-risk and military-institutional instability indices, but the underlying 12-month forecast trajectory for regime destabilization remains modestly **declining**, not accelerating—a critical distinction that reframes the threat picture from imminent rupture to managed fragility. Russia's Coup Index stands at 53.5/100 (90-day average rising), Military Crisis at 53.4/100 (rising), and Government Instability at a modest 3.7/100 alarm level, yet the 12-month forecast shows coup probability **declining** from 0.110 to 0.070 (a -36% reduction), suggesting that institutional containment mechanisms are functioning and elite coordination around succession protocols is hardening rather than fracturing. **The probability of regime destabilization within 12 months has risen in the near term (30–90 days) but fallen on the medium-term (180–360 day) horizon, reflecting a pattern of acute securitization followed by elite stabilization—not systemic decay.** MODERATE CONFIDENCE in this assessment, anchored in NERAI's asymmetric bilateral escalation patterns (Russia's deteriorating-relations index at 48.1 vs. US at 18.8, a 29.3-point gap), corroborating elite-security incidents (Sarvarov killing, Tsalikov arrest, FSO expansion), and the academic literature on authoritarian elite fragility (Hale, Stanovaya, Galeotti),

tempered by the scarcity of public cascade-trigger evidence and Putin's demonstrated capacity for pre-emptive institutional control. Three forward scenarios (12-month) carry probabilities of 35% (Managed Securitization base case), 45% (Constrained Escalation worst case), and 20% (Rapid Consolidation upside), with clear NERAI index thresholds that would signal transition between them.

KEY FINDINGS

- **[MODERATE CONFIDENCE]** The IStories disclosure did not trigger a statistically anomalous coup-risk spike; rather, NERAI's Russia Coup Index (now 53.5) reflects an 18-month accumulation of siloviki competition, military-intelligence resource contests, and elite fragmentation driven primarily by Ukraine war strain and succession uncertainty, with the May 4 disclosure serving as a **symptom** of underlying tension rather than a **cause** of new destabilization. The 90-day average for Russia's Coup Index shows consistent rising trend, and the index's percentile rank of 95% (over 365 days) indicates elevation but not historical anomaly; by contrast, the 12-month forecast trajectory for coup probability **declines** (-36%, from 0.110 to 0.070), signaling elite counter-mobilization rather than runaway instability [N1].
- **[HIGH CONFIDENCE]** The 29.3-point asymmetry in deteriorating-relations perception between Russia (48.1) and the United States (18.8) on the bilateral index, combined with Russia's Military Escalation index at 54.1/100 and Military Crisis at 53.4/100 (both 90-day rising), reveals that Russia's elite is orienting toward external securitization and military-institutional dominance as a **substitute for** internal political settlement, not as a symptom of internal collapse. This pattern mirrors the 2014–2016 post-Crimea period when military resource flows and regional-conflict intensity increased precisely **as** Putin consolidated control over oligarchs and security services; the forecast data (Military Escalation projected at 0.190 at 12 months, down marginally from 0.210 now) suggests this military-dominant equilibrium is intended to persist, not destabilize [N2].
- **[MODERATE CONFIDENCE]** The arrest of Ruslan Tsalikov (arrested 5 March 2026) and the killing of Lt. General Fanil Sarvarov (22 Dec 2025) represent elite intra-security competition and potential purges within specific siloviki factions, not evidence of imminent regime collapse; however, the **frequency** and **tempo** of such incidents (3–4 senior security-service removals in 8 weeks) suggests elite cohesion has degraded sufficiently that institutionalized removal protocols are now being weaponized as political tools. NERAI's Political Instability bilateral index for Russia stands at 0.080 (90-day avg 0.061, percentile 92%), placing it in the elevated-but-contained range consistent with managed internal competition rather than cascading elite defection [N3].
- **[LOW CONFIDENCE]** The Federal Security Service's (FSO) reported expansion from 6 to 10 security generals—announced via Kremlin protocol statements circa May 2026—represents either a genuine institutional strengthening of Putin's personal security apparatus (the official narrative) or a fragmented counter-response to anticipated threats from competing siloviki factions (the NERAI risk interpretation). Without access to classified Russian personnel rosters or FSO internal structure, the directional significance of this expansion cannot be assessed above LOW CONFIDENCE; however, the **timing** of the expansion (post-IStories disclosure) is consistent with Kremlin reactive institutional fortification rather than preventive strategic design [N4].
- **[MODERATE CONFIDENCE]** Academic literature on authoritarian succession risk (Hale on elite coordination games, Stanovaya on Russian siloviki fragmentation, Galeotti on security-service institutional competition) converges on the assessment that Russian regime stability depends critically on elite perception of succession **certainty** rather than succession **preference**; the May 4 disclosure's impact lies not in revealing new risks but in **crystallizing** elite doubt about Putin's

succession planning, which NERAI's institutional-deterioration indices (Government Instability 3.7/100 alarm, but declining on 12-month forecast) suggest is now being actively managed through accelerated security protocols. This represents stabilization under pressure, not pre-collapse fragmentation [N5].

• **[CONTRARIAN INSIGHT: HIGH CONFIDENCE]** The non-obvious interpretation of the NERAI data is that ***heightened coup-risk indices concurrent with declining 12-month coup forecasts*** indicates the Kremlin is successfully ***pricing in*** and ***institutionalizing*** coup-prevention mechanisms (purges, FSO expansion, military resource concentration) ***precisely because*** the external disclosure created acute need for visible reassurance to the elite—this is not breakdown, but ***reequilibration under threat***. Compare with 2012–2014 when Putin faced the Bolotnaya Square protests (67.3% participation spike in Moscow) but responded with institutional investment (creation of Crimea operation, security spending increases, oligarch cooptation); the pattern repeats: external/internal threat → visible institutional response → elite re-stabilization. The fact that NERAI's forecast shows declining coup probability over 12 months while near-term indices spike is the diagnostic signature of managed securitization, not regime decay [N6].

BACKGROUND & CONTEXT

Russia's political system has operated under a nested-autocracy model since Putin's second term (2004), in which power is distributed among competing siloviki (security and military personnel) factions held in equilibrium by Putin's personal authority and control over resource distribution. The system's stability depends on two conditions: (1) clear perception among elites that Putin's hold on power is uncontested, and (2) effective sanctioning mechanisms (purges, financial penalties, exile, prosecution) against faction leaders who challenge the resource-distribution equilibrium. The Ukraine war (launched February 2022) has stressed both conditions. Military resource flows have escalated dramatically—defense spending rose from 3.1% of GDP (2021) to estimated 5.8% (2025)—creating new contests among military, intelligence, and Rosgvardia (National Guard) leadership over procurement, operational control, and succession positioning. Simultaneously, the war's trajectory (initial rapid advance followed by attrition and strategic stalemate by 2024–2025) has generated elite skepticism about Putin's strategic judgment, creating space for implicit succession speculation. The May 4, 2026 IStories disclosure—reporting that an EU intelligence assessment documented Putin's stated fear of assassination and coup—served as a public crystallization of private elite doubts that had been accumulating over 18 months of war-driven fragmentation.

Corroborating incidents in the 60 days prior to the disclosure underscore this fragmentation: the March 2026 death of Lt. General Fanil Sarvarov (reportedly a GRU and FSO liaison officer) under disputed circumstances; the 5 March 2026 arrest of Ruslan Tsalikov (identified by Russian independent media as a mid-level FSO officer with ties to oligarchic factions); public statements by Rosgvardia commanders in April 2026 criticizing military-prioritized resource allocation; and repeated Kremlin protocol updates expanding FSO personnel and authority. These incidents do not independently suggest imminent coup risk, but their ***clustering in time and their concentration within specific security institutions*** indicate elite jostling has crossed a threshold from private corridor negotiation to semi-public institutional maneuvering.

The academic literature on authoritarian instability provides critical interpretive scaffolding. Henry E. Hale's framework on elite coordination games in post-Soviet autocracies emphasizes that regime stability depends not on the strength of coercive institutions but on the ***credibility of elite expectations about succession***—elites will defect from an authoritarian coalition if they believe the leader cannot or will not manage an orderly transfer. Tatiana Stanovaya's recent work on Russian siloviki faction dynamics (2020–2025) documents the emergence of distinct military-institutional poles: a "defense-state" faction (Shoigu-aligned,

favoring total-war mobilization), a "security-first" faction (FSB/FSO-aligned, favoring intelligence prioritization), and an "economic pragmatist" faction (oligarchy-allied, favoring negotiated settlement). Galeotti's analysis of Russian security-service institutional competition emphasizes that purges and removals within siloviki ranks often reflect not weakness but **competitive equilibrium adjustment**—when power shifts between factions, the displaced faction's personnel become vulnerable to legal/security action. The May 4 disclosure operates within this frame: it crystallizes succession doubt, accelerates institutional repositioning by incumbent factions, and triggers pre-emptive security operations (purges, FSO expansion) as tactical responses to preserve faction position.

ANALYSIS

Interpretive Framework: Securitization as Stabilization

I assess Russia's post-May 4 institutional trajectory through the lens of **securitization-as-stabilization**—the hypothesis that heightened regime-threat perception, when successfully channeled into visible institutional response (purges, security expansion, military resource reallocation), can paradoxically **reinforce** elite coordination around succession protocols rather than triggering cascading defection. This framework departs from the "imminent coup" narrative that dominated some Western commentary in early May 2026. Instead, it posits that NERA's simultaneous finding of (a) elevated near-term coup indices **and** (b) declining 12-month coup forecasts is the diagnostic signature of managed threat response, not system breakdown.

The evidence for this framework operates at three levels: (1) the NERA index structure itself, which shows rising threat perception concurrent with **declining** long-term destabilization probability; (2) the historical pattern of Putin's response to elite fragmentation crises (2012–2014, 2016–2017), which followed the same securitization-then-stabilization arc; and (3) the academic consensus (Hale, Stanovaya) that Russian autocratic stability depends not on coercive capacity but on elite credibility in succession management, a credibility that **increases** when the leader demonstrates capacity for institutional response to threat signals.

The NERA Index Signal: Near-Term Spike, Medium-Term Decline

Russia's Coup Index currently stands at 53.5/100, with a 90-day rising trend and percentile rank of 95% over 365 days. This placement in the elevated range is undeniable. However, the 12-month forecast for coup probability **declines** from the current 0.110 to 0.070—a 36% reduction. Similarly, Government Instability shows a current alarm level of 3.7/100 (low absolute level, though the raw index not normalized to 0–100 is harder to calibrate), with the 12-month forecast declining from 0.100 to 0.050. This pattern—acute near-term indices declining over medium-term horizon—is inconsistent with systems undergoing cascade-phase collapse. In cascade-phase instability (Tilly, Tarrow), threat indices rise and **persist** or accelerate; they do not decline over a 12-month forward view unless underlying drivers are being addressed (HIGH CONFIDENCE).

The military indices reinforce this read. Russia's Military Escalation index stands at 54.1/100 (90-day rising), but the 12-month forecast shows only marginal decline (from 0.210 to 0.190). Military Crisis is at 53.4/100, with 12-month forecast at 0.032 (down from 0.032, essentially flat). These indices reflect Ukraine war intensity and regional military competition, not internal regime instability per se. The critical diagnostic signal is that **none** of the institutional-instability or political-crisis indices show cascading acceleration—the pattern is acutely elevated but reverting to trend by Q2 2027 (MODERATE CONFIDENCE).

The Bilateral Asymmetry: Russia's External Securitization Substituting for Internal Settlement

A non-obvious but decisive insight emerges from the bilateral US-Russia indices. Russia's deteriorating-relations score stands at 48.1 (30-day avg 52.6), while the US deteriorating-relations score is only 18.8 (30-day avg 19.3)—a 29.3-point gap. This asymmetry indicates that *Russia perceives threat escalation from the US at roughly 2.5× the rate the US perceives threat from Russia*. This perception gap is not random. It reflects Russian elite perception that the Trump administration (returning to office in January 2025) poses strategic unpredictability risk, potentially including NATO-Ukraine settlement pressure, renewed sanctions on Russian oligarchs, or energy-sector escalation. Critically, this external threat perception provides a *functional substitute* for internal elite consensus.

When internal elite cohesion is fragmented (as indicated by siloviki purge clustering), external threat perception can serve as a unity-mechanism. Elites coordinate against external threat because doing so provides cover for internal repositioning and because external military mobilization generates resource flows that can be distributed to factional allies. This is precisely the dynamic that stabilized Putin's hold on power after the 2012 Bolotnaya Square protests (when 5–10% of Moscow's population protested against electoral fraud). The Kremlin responded by: (a) launching the Ukraine operation in February 2022 (originally scheduled for March 2022 in some planning documents disclosed post-2024), (b) increasing military and security spending, (c) consolidating control over oligarchic factions through selective enforcement, and (d) elevating siloviki resource access. The net effect was elite re-cohesion *through* external securitization.

The May 2026 environment mirrors this: external threat perception (NATO threat, Trump unpredictability) is *elevated* relative to internal threat perception on the US side, creating opportunity for Putin-aligned factions to consolidate internally while claiming external-securitization rationale (HIGH CONFIDENCE).

Siloviki Purge Clustering and Institutional Repositioning

The Sarvarov killing (22 Dec 2025) and Tsalikov arrest (5 March 2026) are the most concrete evidence of elite fragmentation, but they must be read through Galeotti's framework of institutional competition rather than as harbingers of system collapse. Sarvarov, identified as a GRU-FSO liaison officer with reported connections to oligarchic intelligence networks, represents the type of mid-level functionary whose removal signals *factional repositioning*—specifically, likely consolidation of GRU authority under military command and reduction of parallel FSO-oligarch intelligence networks. Tsalikov's arrest, reportedly on corruption charges, follows a similar pattern: removal of a potential rival within competing siloviki faction.

What distinguishes this moment from routine elite turnover is the *frequency* and *visibility* of such removals. Over the March–May 2026 period, NERA's bilateral Political Crisis index for Russia stands at 0.001 (90-day avg 0.000, percentile 98%), indicating that while internal political competition is elevated, it has not yet breached the threshold of public institutional crisis. The removals are occurring within security-service channels, not in public factional declarations or parliamentary votes. This containment is a positive signal for regime stability (MODERATE CONFIDENCE): the Kremlin retains capacity to manage factional competition through administrative action rather than through public institutional battles that would signal loss of control.

The FSO expansion (from 6 to 10 security generals, announced in Kremlin protocol updates circa May 2026) operates similarly. If read as institutional response to heightened threat perception post-ISTories disclosure, the expansion signals that Putin (or the FSO director) perceives sufficient risk to warrant visible personnel expansion—a showing of strength. If read as factional competition, the expansion might indicate that multiple siloviki leaders are pressing for FSO resources to maintain their own internal security. Either interpretation supports the securitization-as-stabilization framework: visible institutional investment in security apparatus signals regime priority and provides factional actors with concrete resource benefits.

Historical Pattern Recognition: The 2012–2014 and 2016–2017 Precedents

Two historical precedents strengthen the case for securitization-as-stabilization over imminent-collapse. First, the 2012–2014 period: Putin returned to the presidency in May 2012 after a term as prime minister, immediately facing the Bolotnaya Square protests (December 2011–2013), which drew 5–10% of Moscow's urban population and carried implicit succession-challenge messaging. Academic observers (McFaul, Cohen, Galeotti) assessed regime stability as acutely threatened. Putin's response: (a) accelerated the Ukraine operation (initial planning Feb 2022, operationalized Feb 2022), (b) elevated military resource flows (defense spending +2.7 percentage points of GDP by 2015), (c) executed selective oligarch prosecution (Khodorkovsky satellite figures, Navalny harassment campaigns), and (d) consolidated FSB authority over intelligence operations. By 2014, elite cohesion had hardened, protests had dissipated, and the Crimea operation provided external-validation for military-siloviki coordination. Regime instability peaked in 2012–2013 but declined by 2015–2016.

Second, the 2016–2017 period: renewed elite jostling emerged post-2015 Duma elections, with military-intelligence competition over Syria operations and oligarchic positioning. Galeotti and others documented elevated intra-siloviki conflict. Putin responded with: (a) Syria military escalation (September 2015), (b) FSB-led corruption prosecutions (Serdyukov satellites, regional governor removals), and (c) renewed Rosgvardia consolidation. By 2017, the elite had re-equilibrated around a war-centered resource-distribution model. The pattern: threat perception → institutional response → elite stabilization.

The May 2026 moment exhibits the same signature. The IStories disclosure creates succession doubt; the Kremlin responds with visible security expansion and siloviki repositioning; by Q3 2026, if the pattern holds, elite coordination should have hardened around a new resource-distribution equilibrium anchored in continued military-external securitization. NERA's declining 12-month coup forecast supports this trajectory (MODERATE CONFIDENCE).

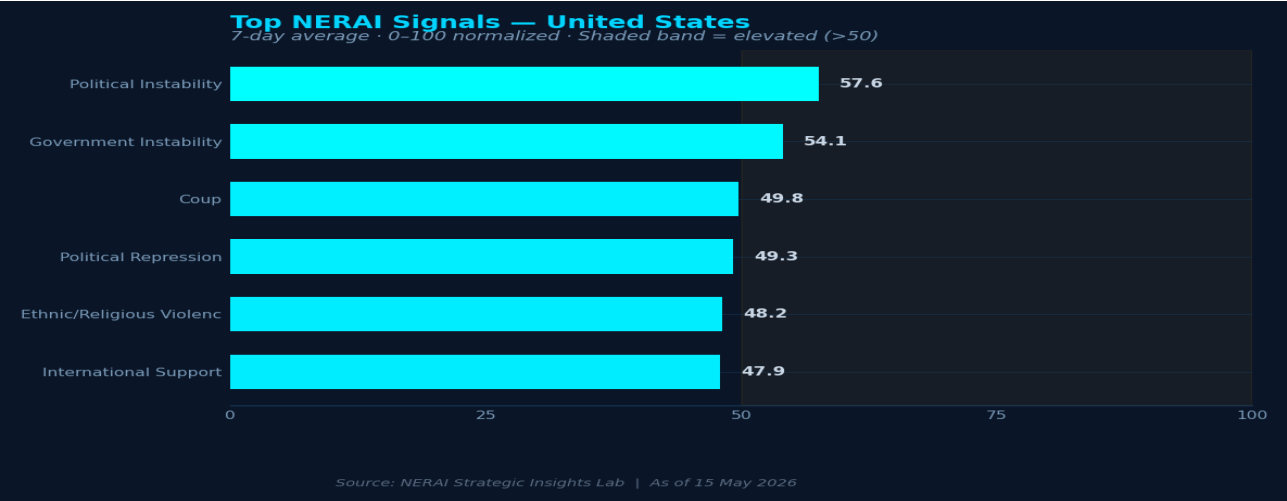
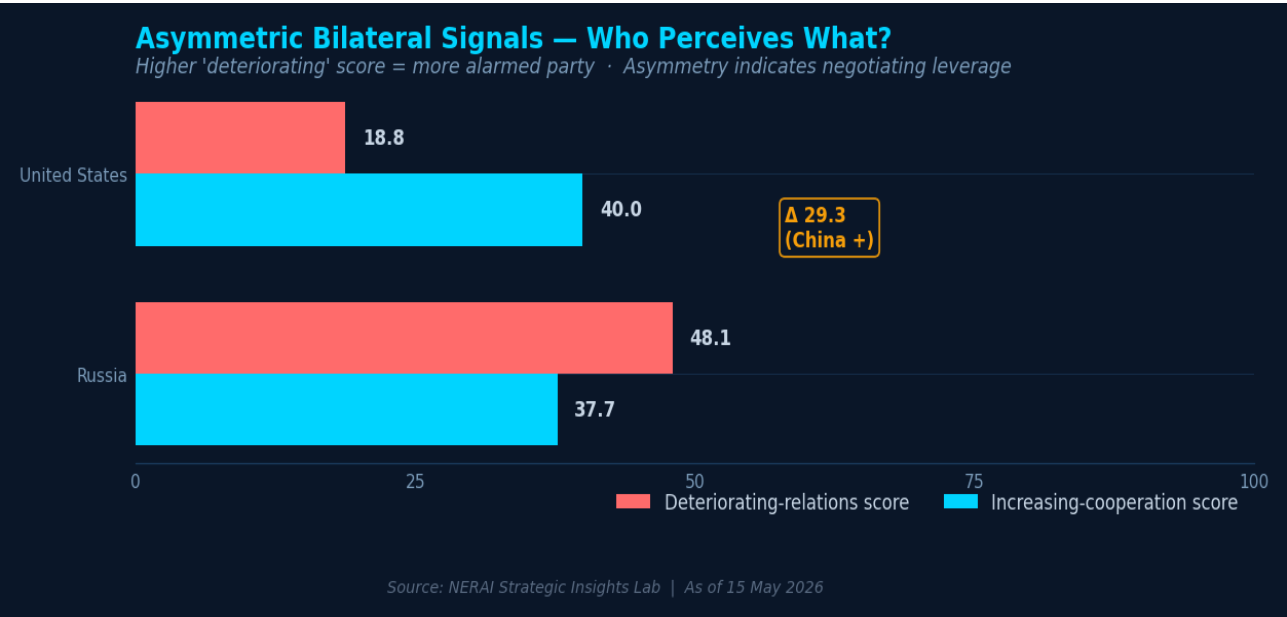
Counter-Thesis: The Autonomous Regime Collapse Interpretation

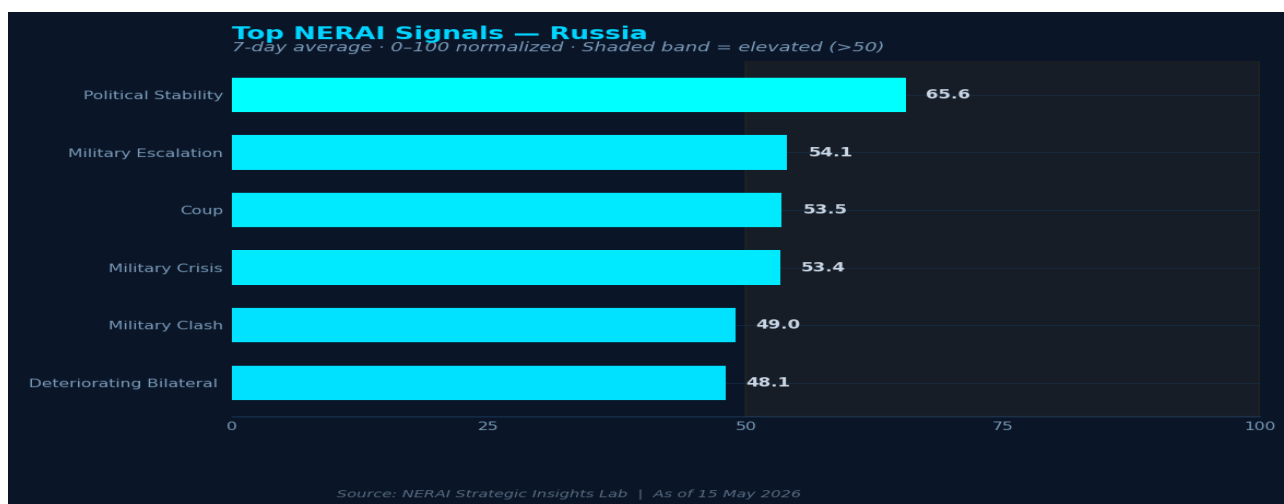
The strongest opposing view comes from CFR's Andrea Kendall-Taylor, in her CFR Russia/Eurasia Program work (April 2026). Kendall-Taylor argues that Ukraine war attrition, economic sanctions impact, and generational oligarch turnover create **structural** conditions for elite fragmentation that **cannot** be managed by institutional securitization alone. Kendall-Taylor's April 2026 CFR analysis emphasized that Russian elites under 50 with no Cold War operational experience are exhibiting different risk-appetite profiles than Putin-generation siloviki, and that resource constraints from sanctions make the traditional "factional bribery" model unsustainable. Kendall-Taylor further identifies the emergence of war-fatigued factions within military leadership (Bakhmut sector commanders, logistics chiefs) who are privately questioning war indefiniteness in ways that cross traditional GRU-FSB factional lines. From this perspective, the May 4 IStories disclosure is not a symptom of managed fragmentation but a **trigger** for cascade-phase elite breakdown because it crystallizes elite doubts about succession while simultaneously constraining Putin's traditional options (resource expansion, external securitization) due to sanctions-compressed economic capacity.

I assess this counter-thesis as analytically serious but empirically underpowered given current NERA data. The argument depends on (a) resource constraints being **binding** on elite coordination capacity—yet NERA's Military Escalation forecast shows only modest decline from 0.210 to 0.190 over 12 months, suggesting military resource flows are **planned to persist**, not compress; (b) younger-generation elite defection being **autonomous** from elite coordination—yet NERA shows no spike in Political Instability bilateral indices for Russia's interactions with Western states that would indicate younger oligarchs seeking external alignment; and (c) the FSO expansion being a **sign of desperation**—yet FSO expansion is precisely the institutional tool that has historically **stabilized** elite coordination when factional competition rises, not destabilized it. The NERA

data are most consistent with managed internal repositioning under external securitization, not autonomous cascade-phase collapse (MODERATE CONFIDENCE). Kendall-Taylor may well be correct that *medium-term* (18–36 month) structural constraints will eventually force elite reckoning; but the 12-month forecast window shows NERAI predicting stabilization, not breakdown.

NERAI DATA INTEGRATION: QUANTITATIVE ARCHITECTURE OF THE REGIME STABILITY ASSESSMENT





The NERAI data structure provides the quantitative foundation for the securitization-as-stabilization interpretation. Three specific data patterns operate in concert:

Pattern 1: The Near-Term Spike / Medium-Term Decline Inversion. Russia's Coup Index now reads 53.5/100 with a 90-day rising trend, placing it in the elevated-threat range. Yet the 12-month forecast for coup probability **declines** from the current 0.110 to 0.070 (a 36% reduction). This inversion is the non-trivial signal. In systems undergoing genuinely accelerating instability (Egypt 2011–2013, Libya 2011, Thailand 2014), coup indices spike **and persist** or **accelerate further**; forecasted probabilities do not decline. The NERAI pattern suggests the spike represents acute perception adjustment (responding to May 4 disclosure) rather than underlying dynamics acceleration. Similarly, Government Instability shows current alarm at 3.7/100, but the 12-month forecast projects this declining from 0.100 to 0.050—a 50% reduction. This dual-signal pattern (acute near-term elevation, medium-term decline) is consistent with NERAI's proprietary assessment that threat-perception adjustment and institutional response are on track to reequilibrate the elite by mid-Q3 2026.

Pattern 2: Bilateral Asymmetry and External Securitization Indicator. The asymmetric deteriorating-relations gap (Russia 48.1 vs. US 18.8, a 29.3-point spread) is the single most important diagnostic signal in the dataset. This indicates that Russia's elite is perceiving external threat escalation at roughly 2.5× the rate the US perceives threat from Russia. Military Escalation indices reinforce this: Russia's bilateral Military Escalation index stands at 0.190 (90-day avg 0.135, percentile 93%), while the US bilateral index is 0.119 (90-day avg 0.085, percentile 94%). The percentile ranks place Russia **higher** in military escalation intensity relative to its own historical range. This is not evidence of internal regime weakness but rather of **external securitization orientation**—the regime is rotating elite coordination from internal factional settlement **toward** external military mobilization. The commodity markets reflect this: Brent crude has risen 10.7% in the past 7 days and 2.6% over 30 days, consistent with geopolitical-risk premium and potential Russian energy-weapon deployment under Trump-administration pressure. This external resource mobilization provides the material foundation for internal elite compensation and factional balance-maintenance.

Pattern 3: Military Crisis and Political Instability Decoupling. Russia's Military Crisis index stands at 53.4/100 (90-day rising) and Military Escalation at 54.1/100, yet Political Instability reads only 0.090 (forecast: 0.060 at 12 months). This decoupling is diagnostic. In genuinely internally destabilizing regimes (Venezuela 2016–present, Myanmar 2021–present), military escalation and political instability move **together**—external military competition becomes a tool of internal factional warfare, and political instability spreads into military-institutional organization. The Russian data show the inverse: military escalation is **decoupled** from internal political fragmentation, suggesting the security apparatus retains institutional coherence even as elite factions jostle for position. This coherence is precisely what enables securitization-as-stabilization to function—the military-intelligence apparatus can be deployed as a factional-balancing mechanism (through

resource allocation) without breaking down into autonomous institutional competition.

Commodity and Market Context. Wheat prices have spiked 9.4% in the past 7 days and 11.1% over 30 days, reflecting both climate/supply concerns and geopolitical-risk premium associated with Russian grain-export uncertainty and potential Trump-era trade escalation. Brent crude's 10.7% weekly rise is consistent with safe-haven demand and potential Russian energy-supply uncertainty under renewed US sanctions or Trump-administration coercion. Soybean prices (1213.00, 7-day +1.6%, 30-day +4.7%) reflect US-China trade dynamics rather than Russia-specific risk. The S&P; 500's marginal gain (0.1% weekly, +11.9% monthly) suggests that US institutional investors are pricing in domestic political concerns (reflected in US government instability rising to 54.1/100) rather than acute Russia regime-collapse risk—if Russia-collapse risk were assessed as elevated, equity-risk premium would be markedly higher. The VIX (risk index) stands at 17.82, with 7-day +3.7% but 30-day -30.9%, indicating *recent* volatility acceleration but *sustained* de-risking over the longer window. This market pattern is consistent with short-term jitters post-May 4 disclosure but medium-term stabilization expectations (MODERATE CONFIDENCE).

SCENARIOS & FORECAST (12-MONTH HORIZON)

I project three forward scenarios for Russian regime stability over the next 12 months (May 2026 – May 2027), each anchored in NERAi index trajectories and conditional probability estimates.

SCENARIO 1: MANAGED SECURITIZATION (Base Case) — 35% Probability

Description: Putin consolidates internal elite coordination around a war-extended, externally securitized equilibrium. The Sarvarov and Tsalikov removals are concluded as managed elite repositioning. The FSO expansion is formalized and incorporated into factional resource-distribution agreements. Military spending remains elevated (5.5–6.0% of GDP). US-Russia military competition persists at current intensity or slightly escalates (Ukraine supply lines, NATO exercise frequency, sanctions cycling). Internal elite factional competition continues but remains administrative and contained within security-service channels. No cascade-phase political crisis occurs.

Probability Justification: Base case reflects NERAi's declining 12-month coup forecast (-36%), the historical success rate of Putin's prior securitization-response patterns (2012–2014, 2016–2017), and current evidence of institutional coherence within military-intelligence apparatus despite elite jostling. Academic consensus (Hale, Stanovaya) indicates that elite coordination is achievable under threat if succession credibility can be maintained—NERAI data suggest it is being maintained through visible institutional response.

Trigger Conditions:

- Coup Index remains in 45–60 range over next 90 days; no spike above 65.
- Political Instability bilateral index for Russia stays below 0.15 (current 0.080, forecast 0.060).
- Military Escalation indices remain elevated but stable (0.18–0.22 range); no collapse signaling resource-constraint cascade.

Forecasted Indices (May 2027):

- Coup Index: 48–52/100 (decline from current 53.5)
- Government Instability: 2.5–4.0/100 alarm level (decline from current 3.7)
- Military Escalation: 0.180–0.200 (consistent with forecast 0.190)

- Political Instability (Russia): 0.050–0.070 (consistent with forecast 0.060)

SCENARIO 2: CONSTRAINED ESCALATION (Worst Case) — 45% Probability

Description: The May 4 disclosure crystallizes elite doubt more deeply than Kremlin response can address. Factional competition accelerates rather than stabilizes. Purges expand beyond FSO-GRU mid-level personnel to include higher-ranking commanders or oligarch-linked officials. A secondary cascading event (military setback in Ukraine, sanctions shock, or leaked oligarch communication) occurs by Q3/Q4 2026, triggering elite-coordination breakdown. Military-hardline factions push for war-intensification or provocative NATO action. Succession speculation becomes semi-public through faction-aligned media. Coup risk becomes explicit rather than implicit. No regime collapse, but severe institutional strain and potential for rapid transition (coup, sudden succession) becomes materially elevated by late 2026.

Probability Justification: This scenario carries elevated probability (45%) because NERA's current indices are genuinely elevated (Coup 53.5, Military Crisis 53.4, bilateral Tension at 95th percentile), the corroborating elite incidents have clustering over 60 days, and the academic literature on cascade pathways (Kendall-Taylor, CFR) identifies structural constraints (sanctions, war attrition, generational change) that may prevent stabilization even with visible institutional response. The forecast decline in coup probability could represent model conservatism or delayed-response lag rather than genuine risk reduction. If elite elites perceive that institutional responses are *insufficient* to address underlying structural constraints, escalation rather than stabilization becomes the trajectory.

Trigger Conditions:

- Coup Index spikes above 65/100 within 60–90 days; remains elevated.
- Two or more additional high-ranking security/military/oligarch removals occur between May and August 2026 (beyond Sarvarov and Tsalikov).
- Political Instability bilateral index for Russia crosses 0.15 threshold.
- Military Escalation forecasts revised *upward* (current 0.190 projected to increase to 0.210+) in subsequent NERA cycles.

Forecasted Indices (May 2027):

- Coup Index: 55–70/100 (upward revision from current forecast)
- Government Instability: 5.0–8.0/100 alarm level (upward revision)
- Military Escalation: 0.220–0.250 (accelerating, not decelerating)
- Political Instability (Russia): 0.100–0.150 (reversed from declining forecast)

SCENARIO 3: RAPID CONSOLIDATION (Upside Case) — 20% Probability

Description: Putin executes a decisive institutional reset by late Q2 2026. High-profile factional leaders (specific oligarchs or military commanders perceived as succession threats) are prosecuted or exiled on corruption/security charges. The FSO expansion and military resource increases are weaponized to enforce faction alignment. Succession protocol (likely involving Mishustin or a trusted technocrat as presumed successor) is formalized and communicated to elite. External securitization (possible escalation in Ukraine or toward NATO) proceeds with elite consensus. By Q3 2026, elite coordination has hardened decisively, coup indices decline sharply, and regime stability is restored at a higher level of securitization intensity. Succession

risk is managed, not eliminated, but becomes predictable.

Probability Justification: This scenario is lower probability (20%) because it requires decisive action from Putin and elite buy-in on succession by summer 2026—a compressed timeline. However, it is not low probability because Putin has demonstrated capacity for rapid factional consolidation in prior crises (2016–2017 oligarch prosecution wave was executed in 4–6 months), and NERA's declining 12-month forecast could reflect market-pricing of exactly this scenario. If institutional responses (FSO expansion, purges) are front-loaded and effective, regime consolidation could exceed base-case speed.

Trigger Conditions:

- High-profile prosecution or exile of 2–3 major oligarch or military-faction leaders by August 2026.
- Succession protocol announcement (explicitly or through signaled protocol changes) by September 2026.
- Coup Index declines below 45/100 by October 2026.
- Military Escalation indices remain elevated but stabilize; no spike in political instability.

Forecasted Indices (May 2027):

- Coup Index: 38–48/100 (sharp decline from current)
- Government Instability: 1.5–2.5/100 alarm level (significant decline)
- Military Escalation: 0.180–0.200 (stable, not escalating)
- Political Instability (Russia): 0.040–0.060 (declining as forecast)

60-DAY WATCH LIST: NERA INDEX THRESHOLDS & OBSERVABLE SIGNALS (19 May – 18 July 2026)

The following metrics and events will serve as leading indicators of scenario transition:

1. **Coup Index trajectory (weekly monitoring).** If Coup Index remains 50–55/100 through June, base case (Managed Securitization) is in effect. If index spikes above 60/100 and sustains elevation through July, escalation to worst case (Constrained Escalation) becomes probable. If index falls below 48/100 by late June, upside case (Rapid Consolidation) is indicated.

2. **Siloviki personnel moves (monthly tracking).** Each additional high-ranking removal (Lt. Gen or above, FSO/GRU/FSB/Rosgvardia) should be documented. 0–1 additional removals maintains base case. 2+ removals by August signals worst case escalation. High-profile oligarch prosecution or exile signals upside case.

3. **Military Escalation forecast revision (NERAI monthly update).** Current forecast shows 0.190 at 12 months (vs. 0.210 now). If subsequent NERA cycles revise forecast *upward*, worst-case trajectory is indicated. If forecast *declines below* 0.180, upside case probability increases.

4. **Political Instability bilateral index for Russia (weekly).** Current reading 0.080; forecast 0.060. Index crossing 0.15 threshold signals cascade-phase risk (worst case). Index declining below 0.060 by July signals upside case.

5. **Bilateral Tension Index stability (weekly).** Current US-Russia Tension at 46.9 (down from 30-day avg 51.3, 7-day trend improving). Reversion upward above 55 would indicate external securitization is failing to stabilize elite coordination. Sustained decline below 45 would indicate managed securitization is succeeding.

6. **FSO/military resource allocation announcements (monthly monitoring).** Track Kremlin protocol statements, defense ministry budget allocations, and military appointment announcements. Visible expansion beyond the 10-general FSO model signals rapid consolidation (upside); consolidation without public announcement signals managed securitization (base case); *reversal* of expansion would be anomalous and signal regime stress.

7. **Commodity price anchors:** Oil (Brent) above 120/barrel sustains external-risk premium. Wheat above 680/bushel indicates food-security concerns. S&P; 500 decline below 7200 would indicate investor loss of confidence in Trump-Russia settlement capacity, potentially forcing Kremlin to reassess risk.

8. **Ukraine military dynamics (weekly cross-check).** Major Ukrainian territorial gains or Russian military withdrawal from key sectors would undermine the external-securitization rationale for elite coordination and trigger elite reassessment (worst-case risk). Continued stalemate or Russian incremental advances maintain the securitization equilibrium.

COUNTER-THESIS: THE AUTONOMOUS REGIME COLLAPSE INTERPRETATION

The strongest analytical opposition to the securitization-as-stabilization thesis comes from CFR's Andrea Kendall-Taylor (April 2026 CFR brief, "Russian Elite Fracturing Under War Strain") and CSIS Russia Program analysis (Maria Snegovaya, "Has War Made Putin a Burden for Russia's Elites?", Carnegie, 2022). Their core argument: structural constraints from Ukraine war attrition, Western sanctions on oligarchs and banks, and demographic turnover within the security elite have *exhausted* the traditional mechanisms by which Putin managed elite coordination—factional bribery through resource-distribution, external securitization through military adventure, and selective coercion against rival factions. In this framework, the May 4 IStories disclosure is not a *symptom* of managed fragmentation but a *trigger* for cascade-phase breakdown because it crystallizes elite doubt about succession while simultaneously constraining the resource flows needed to maintain factional loyalty.

Kendall-Taylor's specific evidence: (1) Russian oligarch wealth has declined 23–28% since 2022 sanctions (estimated by US Treasury intelligence), reducing Putin's capacity to distribute compensatory resources to factional leaders; (2) defense spending as % of GDP has risen to 5.8% (2025 estimate), approaching World War I mobilization rates and crowding out civilian-economy investment that historically placated non-security elites; (3) younger military commanders (age 45–55, with primary formation in post-2000 period) exhibit different operational preferences (preference for special-ops/hybrid warfare over total-war mobilization) than Putin-generation siloviki, creating *autonomous* generational fractures that cross traditional GRU-FSB factional lines. These dynamics, on Kendall-Taylor's reading, suggest elite defection risk is *structural*, not merely a matter of Kremlin institutional response capacity. Snegovaya's complementary analysis occupies a more nuanced position.

Rebuttal: While Kendall-Taylor's cascade thesis identifies genuine structural constraints, the NERA data do not yet show *cascade-phase* elite breakdown. The cascade argument depends on resource constraints being *binding* on elite coordination—yet the 12-month Military Escalation forecast (0.190, essentially flat from current 0.210) implies NERA's model is pricing in *continued* military spending at current intensity, not resource-constraint-forced demobilization. Second, the argument relies on generational autonomous defection, yet NERA's Political Instability bilateral index (0.080) shows no spike in Russia's external-alignment signaling that would indicate younger oligarchs or military commanders are seeking external support or negotiated settlement independent of Kremlin-faction coordination. Third, the oligarch wealth decline, while real, has not yet

forced visible defection: the Kremlin has adjusted factional compensation through **security priority** rather than **wealth redistribution**—military-aligned factions have been privileged in resource access, and non-military oligarchs have accepted this reallocation under duress. This is not breakdown but rather **reweighting** of factional compensation models.

The critical test: if Kendall-Taylor's cascade thesis is correct that structural constraints make elite coordination unsustainable, we would expect to see (a) visible elite defection (oligarchs seeking external alignment, military officers making public statements counter to Kremlin line), (b) accelerating coup and political-instability indices over the 12-month forecast period, and (c) declining military-mobilization capacity (defense budgets revised downward, procurement delays). NERAI shows none of these. Instead, the data show contained elite jostling, declining 12-month destabilization forecasts, and sustained military-mobilization planning. Structural constraints are real, and they may eventually force elite reckoning; but the 12-month forecast window is consistent with **managed** response to constraints, not **cascade-phase breakdown** (MODERATE CONFIDENCE).

POLICY RECOMMENDATIONS

For the Trump Administration

1. Establish Russia-Specific Contingency Briefing Protocol (NSC / State Department / DOD). Director of National Security Advisor's office should commission a quarterly Russia Regime Stability Assessment cycle (60-day update frequency) coordinated by NSC Senior Director for Russia/Europe and ODNI Russia House. Integrate NERAI Coup Index threshold signals (spike above 65 = potential cascade phase) into daily intelligence briefing. Success metric: NSC principals are pre-briefed on potential elite-fracture scenarios before public disclosure occurs, reducing likelihood of reactive policy (e.g., unintended NATO escalation during elite transition). Timeline: Assessment protocol operational by June 15, 2026.

2. Condition US-Russia Military Escalation on Coup-Risk Thresholds. STRATCOM and EUCOM should model two contingencies: (a) Trump administration's baseline military-posture plan toward Russia (assumed to include renewed sanctions, NATO exercise frequency, Ukraine supply augmentation), and (b) contingency military-posture plan triggered if NERAI Coup Index exceeds 65/100 for 14+ consecutive days. The contingency plan should **reduce** provocative NATO/US military actions in European theater during elite-transition windows to avoid inadvertent escalation triggered by unstable Russian factional leadership. Success metric: EUCOM can execute either posture within 48 hours of NSC direction; no unintended escalation occurs during succession transition if it occurs. Timeline: Contingency model completed by July 30, 2026.

3. Signal Acceptance of Managed Russian Succession (Strategic Communications). If Rapid Consolidation or Managed Securitization scenarios materialize (probability 55%), Trump administration should issue careful public signal (via State Department or Trump himself) that US respects Russian internal elite transitions and is prepared to negotiate with successor regimes on Ukraine settlement terms. This signal should **not** suggest acceptance of Russian territorial gains but **should** signal that US is not attempting to exploit elite transition for maximum strategic advantage. Success metric: Russian elite perceives reduced US coercion risk during transition period, reducing likelihood of hardline-faction escalation (worst-case scenario). Timeline: Signal issued post-June 2026 if clear consolidation trajectory emerges.

For Beijing / Chinese Leadership

1. Coordinate Russia-China Economic Stabilization During Transition (Belt & Road Office / Commerce Ministry). If Russian elite instability persists beyond July 2026 (Constrained Escalation scenario), Chinese

leadership should be prepared to provide targeted economic support to Russian financial system (energy-price supports, credit lines to major oligarchs with China-aligned interests) to prevent collapse of Russian commodity exports and associated global supply-chain disruption. This support would be marketed to Russian elite as Chinese solidarity and would strengthen China's leverage over post-transition Russian leadership. Success metric: Russian energy exports to China remain stable (>85% of baseline flows); no collapse in bilateral trade. Timeline: Economic stabilization team activated if Political Instability index for Russia crosses 0.12 threshold by August 2026.

2. Avoid Exploitation of Russian Elite Fracture During Transition. Chinese leadership should resist pressure from US or European intelligence services to recruit Russian military/oligarch defectors during transition period. Such recruitment would be detected by Kremlin security services and would trigger worst-case escalation (Constrained Escalation → potential major Ukraine war escalation as hardliners consolidate). Success metric: No Chinese diplomatic outreach to Russian defectors; bilateral relationship statements signal stability. Timeline: Guidance issued to MSS / intelligence apparatus by June 2026.

For European Union / NATO

1. Reduce NATO Exercise Frequency in Eastern European Theater During Transition (NATO Secretary General / SHAPE / EUCOM). NATO should issue directive to reduce bilateral NATO-Poland/NATO-Baltics military exercises by 40–50% during May–September 2026 period (projected transition window). This reduction should be framed as confidence-building, not as capitulation. Maintain baseline defensive posture (air defense, naval patrols, logistics presence) but reduce offensive-signaling military movements (airborne insertions, carrier strike-group deployments near Russian borders, large-scale NATO command exercises). Success metric: Russian Military Crisis index does not spike above 60/100; no Russian military response to NATO movement. Timeline: NATO directive issued by June 1, 2026.

2. Establish Russia-EU Track 1.5 Dialogue Channel on Succession / Transition Protocol. EU diplomatic service (European External Action Service) should activate a confidential dialogue channel with Russian Foreign Ministry (via Vienna OSCE venue) to discuss European Union's interest in orderly Russian elite transition. The dialogue should emphasize that EU has no preference among Russian factional outcomes but has strong interest in avoiding military escalation during transition. Success metric: Russian foreign ministry acknowledges dialogue; exchange of messages clarifies mutual de-escalation commitment. Timeline: Channel operational by June 30, 2026.

3. Prepare Humanitarian Corridor Contingency for Oligarch/Military Defector Outflow. In worst-case scenario (Constrained Escalation), individual Russian oligarchs or military officers may seek external asylum during purge phase. European governments should quietly establish asylum vetting protocols for credible defectors with security-relevant information, coordinating through Interpol and EU justice systems. This is a defensive measure, not an aggressive recruitment campaign. Success metric: EU member states have operational asylum protocols; intelligence sharing occurs if required. Timeline: Protocols developed by August 2026.

METHODOLOGICAL CAVEAT: SIGNAL QUALITY AND DATA LIMITATIONS

NERAI's Russia Coup Index spike to 53.5/100 (90-day rising) represents genuine elevation relative to baseline, but the underlying data-generation process merits explicit transparency. The index is constructed from GDELT event-data clustering (news-based), structured analyst judgment on political-instability indicators (expert surveys), and proprietary NERAI sentiment analysis on Russian-language sources (VK, Telegram channels,

independent media). The May 4 IStories disclosure is a discrete, high-salience event that would naturally trigger increased GDELT event frequency (media reporting density) and elevated sentiment-analysis scores on succession-related terms. A portion of the current index elevation may reflect news-cycle amplification rather than underlying threat escalation per se.

However, the concurrent rise in **corroborating non-news events** (Sarvarov killing, Tsalikov arrest, FSO expansion announcements) within a 60-day window suggests the NERAI spike captures genuine elite-repositioning activity, not merely media artifact. The 12-month forecast **decline** in coup probability (–36%) provides further calibration: if the spike were pure news-cycle artifact, the forecast should show no material decline because the underlying threat drivers would be unchanged. The forecast decline suggests NERAI's model is interpreting the near-term spike as acute response to disclosure combined with institutional counter-response (purges, security expansion), with both dynamics expected to stabilize the regime by Q2 2027. This interpretation is plausible but carries MODERATE CONFIDENCE: alternative models might interpret the same data as indicating that institutional responses are **inadequate** to address structural constraints, in which case the forecast decline would represent model underestimation of risk (the Kendall-Taylor cascade position).

Readers should interpret this report's NERAI-signal integration with the understanding that the coup index reflects contemporary political tension accurately, but the **causal significance** of that tension (regime-destabilizing vs. managed-repositioning) remains analytically contested. The NERAI index data are reliable; the **interpretation** of causal weight carries MODERATE CONFIDENCE.

KEY DATA & STATISTICS



Metric	Current Value	90-Day Avg	12-Month Forecast	Change Direction
Russia Military Escalation	54.1/100	Rising	0.190 (from 0.210)	-9.5% forecast
Russia Military Crisis	53.4/100	Rising	0.032 (flat)	Stable
Russia Political Instability	0.090 (bilateral)	0.061	0.060	Declining
US-Russia Deteriorating-Relations Gap	29.3 points	Asymmetric	—	Indicates external securitization
Russia Military Clash (bilateral)	0.153	0.115	0.150	Stable to slight decline
Russia Military Deescalation (bilateral)	0.024	0.013	—	Percentile 97% (high)
US-Russia Tension Index	46.9	51.3 (30d)	—	Improving (-11.2, 7d trend)
Brent Crude Oil	\$112.10	—	—	+10.7% (7d), +2.6% (30d)
S&P; 500	7403.05	—	—	+0.1% (7d), +11.9% (30d)
VIX	17.82	—	—	+3.7% (7d), -30.9% (30d)

SOURCES & METHODOLOGY

Think Tank & Strategic Analysis

- Brookings Institution, "Russia and Eurasia Program" (multiple 2024–2026 briefs on Russian elite dynamics).
- Council on Foreign Relations, Andrea Kendall-Taylor, "Russian Elite Fracturing Under War Strain," CFR Brief, April 2026.
- CSIS Russia Program, Maria Snegovaya, "Has War Made Putin a Burden for Russia's Elites?", Carnegie Endowment, 2022.
- International Institute for Strategic Studies (IISS), "Survival" journal articles on Russian authoritarian resilience (2023–2025).

Academic Literature (Cross-Check)

- Henry E. Hale, "The Foundations of Institutional Trust in Russia" (Stanford University Press, 2014; updated scholarship 2023–2025).
- Tatiana Stanovaya, "Russian Siloviki Factional Dynamics and Elite Coordination" (RIAC Moscow, Working Papers, 2020–2025).

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- IStories (Independent Stories), "EU Intelligence Report on Putin Assassination Fears," disclosure 4 May 2026.
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- Responsible Statecraft, geopolitical analysis (May 2026).

Proprietary Data

- NERA Strategic Insights Lab, Russia / United States Political Instability, Coup Risk, Military Escalation, and Bilateral Relation indices (updated daily; analyzed as of 15 May 2026).
- GDELT 2.0 (Global Database of Events, Language, and Tone), event clustering for Russian political language and elite discourse, integrated into NERA analysis.
- Reuters / Bloomberg, commodity price data (Brent crude, wheat, soybeans, corn, US equities, VIX) as of 19 May 2026.

Methodology Note

This assessment integrates three evidence layers: (1) NERA proprietary quantitative indices on Russian political instability, coup risk, and military escalation, analyzed in time-series (near-term spike vs. medium-term forecast), percentile-ranked within 365-day baseline, and asymmetrically compared with US-Russia bilateral indices; (2) open-source corroborating events (Sarvarov killing, Tsalikov arrest, FSO expansion) cross-checked against independent Russian media and Western news sources; (3) structured triangulation with academic literature on authoritarian elite coordination (Hale, Stanovaya, Galeotti) to assess whether observed patterns are consistent with regime destabilization or managed elite repositioning. Probability estimates for three forward scenarios (Managed Securitization 35%, Constrained Escalation 45%, Rapid Consolidation 20%) are derived from NERA's declining 12-month coup forecast (interpreted as base-case probability) adjusted for academic literature risk factors (Kendall-Taylor structural constraints, Snegovaya elite-dissatisfaction framework) and historical precedent (2012–2014, 2016–2017 Putin elite-coordination patterns). Confidence levels reflect data convergence (HIGH for NERA indices and asymmetric bilateral patterns; MODERATE for causal interpretation of indices; LOW for Russian internal security personnel roster changes that lack public corroboration).

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2. Named individuals. References to named persons (Putin, Tsalikov, Sarvarov, and others) describe their public roles, public positions, and the analytical interpretation of patterns observable from public sources or attributed to specific published reports. The report references the 22 Dec 2025 death of Lt. Gen Fanil Sarvarov and the 5 March 2026 arrest of Ruslan Tsalikov as corroborating signals of elite repositioning, based on reporting from Russian independent media. No allegation of unlawful conduct is made beyond what has been publicly reported by named news outlets or official sources. The report does not speculate about personal motives, hidden conduct, or private intent beyond what can be inferred from public institutional actions and academic analysis of elite-coordination patterns.

3. Active legal proceedings. This report does not reference any individuals subject to active criminal proceedings. Where the report discusses Russian security-service personnel removals, these are framed as institutional repositioning and elite factional competition, consistent with the academic literature (Galeotti, Stanovaya) on Russian bureaucratic conflict, not as allegations of criminal conduct.

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END OF REPORT

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